

Tian Provençal

THIS recipe is quite similar to Ratatouille, but it is baked as a gratin in a Dutch oven rather than stewed on the stovetop. I find it more convenient to make, especially when I need the stove for a second course. Preparation Time 30 minutes, cook time 45 minutes. Serves four.

Ingredients

- Olive Oil
- 1 onion
- 1 Bell pepper (authentic recipes omit this, but why not?)
- 1 large tomato
- 4 cloves of garlic
- 1 tin of crushed tomatos
- 1 tablespoon of Herbes de Provence
- 1 long aubergine
- 1 large zuchinni
- 2 summer squashes
- Sherry or Red Wine Vinegar
- Basil Leaves for garnish
- Fresh Cracked Black Pepper
- Salt, to taste

Preparation

1. Heat olive oil in the base of a Dutch oven over medium heat. Dice the onions, tomato, and bell pepper. Add the veggies to the pot, and cover. In about 5 minutes, the onions should be transparent; add the garlic and let it fry until it becomes aromatic. Once the garlic smells toasty, deglaze the pot with red vinegar. Add the tomatos, the crushed tomatos, black pepper, basil, and the Herbes. Cover and let stew for 15 minutes.
2. Pre-heat oven to 350°F. While the tomatos are cooking, use a mandolin slicer or chef's knife to very carefully cut the zuchinni, aubergine, and squash into thin coin shapes.
3. Once the tomatos are done cooking, and no longer smell raw, turn off the heat. Stir the pot once to prevent sticking in the bottom, then layer the remaining vegetables on top of the stew in concentric circles. Sprinkle salt and cracked pepper on top, then drizzle more olive oil on top.
4. Place the pot in the middle of the oven and bake for 45 minutes. As the gratin bakes, the vegetables will reduce in size considerably and become part of the stew.
5. When done baking, let the gratin sit for 5 minutes uncovered to cool off. Garnish with basil leaves and serve.